

Postmortem INC-2063: Customers charged twice after gateway timeouts

Field: Value

Date: 2026-05-19

Severity: SEV-1

Duration: 47 minutes of elevated gateway latency

Customer impact: 233 customers double-charged, 12 triple-charged. \$18,420 refunded.

Status: Refunds issued. Root cause fix pending.

Summary

During a gateway latency spike, calls to charge took longer than our client timeout. The gateway had already captured the payment, but we saw `GatewayTimeout`, retried, and captured it again.

What we know

- The gateway supports an `idempotency_key` parameter: repeated calls with the same key return the original charge instead of creating a new one.
- Our retry wrapper lives in `shopfront.payments`.

Action items

1. Find the root cause and fix it so a retried charge can never capture twice.
2. Add a regression test with a gateway that captures the charge *and then* times out.
3. Prevent any retry of a non-idempotent external call without an idempotency key, anywhere in the codebase.